FREE RESOURCE · AI & FINANCE AUTOMATION

10 Finance Tasks to Automate First

Prioritised by effort-to-impact ratio — with tool recommendations, implementation sequence, and a before-you-start checklist for each task.

10 tasks	**Ranked** by ROI	**Tools** per task	**Checklist** included

HOW TO USE THIS CHECKLIST

Tasks are ranked **1–10 by effort-to-impact ratio** — task 1 gives you the highest return for the lowest implementation effort. Work through them sequentially if you are building an automation programme from scratch, or use the effort/impact ratings to prioritise based on your organisation's specific constraints.

Each task includes: a **why automate** rationale, **what to automate** (the specific sub-processes), **tool options** at different price points, effort/impact ratings, time-to-value estimate, and a **before-you-start checklist** of the actions that consistently determine whether the automation succeeds or fails.

01 Expense Report Processing & Policy Checking

T&E; — receipt capture, coding, policy validation, approval routing

EFFORT: LOW | **IMPACT: HIGH** | **TIME TO VALUE: 4–8 weeks**

WHY AUTOMATE THIS

Finance teams spend a disproportionate amount of time on expense administration — collecting receipts, checking coding, chasing missing information, and manually enforcing policy. Every hour spent on this is an hour not spent on analysis. Expense automation produces immediate, measurable time savings and is one of the few finance automations that also improves the employee experience.

WHAT TO AUTOMATE

- Receipt capture via OCR — eliminating manual data entry
- Automated policy checking at point of submission — not at review
- Approval routing based on amount, category, and cost centre
- ERP posting without manual re-keying
- Exception flagging for out-of-policy items requiring human review

TOOL OPTIONS

SAP Concur / Expensya / Pleo	End-to-end T&E; platforms with built-in policy engine and ERP connectors
Microsoft Power Automate	For approval routing and notification workflows where a T&E; platform is already in place
AI prompts (e.g. Copilot)	For out-of-policy commentary and exception reporting — see Prompt 19 in this library

BEFORE YOU START — CHECKLIST

- ■ Document your current expense policy before touching any system
- ■ Map the approval hierarchy for each entity before configuring routing
- ■ Define what out-of-policy means technically — thresholds per category, per country
- ■ Run a 4-week pilot with one business unit before full rollout
- ■ Measure adoption rate at 30 and 60 days post-go-live

02 Month-End Close Task Management

Close — task sequencing, status tracking, bottleneck identification

EFFORT: LOW | **IMPACT: HIGH** | **TIME TO VALUE: 2–4 weeks**

WHY AUTOMATE THIS

The month-end close is the most process-intensive recurring event in the finance calendar. Most organisations run it with a combination of spreadsheets, email chains, and manual status updates. Automating the task management layer — not the accounting itself — reduces close duration and identifies bottlenecks before they become delays.

WHAT TO AUTOMATE

- Close checklist distribution and status tracking by owner
- Automated reminders at defined intervals before task due dates
- Escalation triggers when tasks are overdue beyond a threshold
- Real-time close status dashboard visible to the finance controller

- Post-close time analysis to identify recurring bottlenecks

TOOL OPTIONS

BlackLine / Trintech Cadency	Purpose-built close management platforms with task tracking, reconciliation, and journal entry workflows
Microsoft Planner + Power Automate	Lower-cost option for teams not ready for dedicated close management software
Smartsheet	Mid-range option with strong automation and visibility features

BEFORE YOU START — CHECKLIST

- ■ Document the full close task list before building any automation
- ■ Assign a single owner to every task — shared ownership means no ownership
- ■ Define the close calendar for 12 months ahead before configuring deadlines
- ■ Set escalation thresholds (e.g. task overdue by 4 hours triggers alert to controller)
- ■ Run a retrospective after the first automated close — the first cycle surfaces issues the design missed

03 Bank Reconciliation

Controls — automated matching of bank transactions to ledger entries

EFFORT: LOW | IMPACT: HIGH | TIME TO VALUE: 2–6 weeks

WHY AUTOMATE THIS

Manual bank reconciliation is time-consuming, error-prone, and adds no analytical value. It is one of the highest-volume, lowest-complexity tasks in finance — which makes it one of the strongest candidates for automation. Automated reconciliation also reduces the risk of undetected errors remaining open for extended periods.

WHAT TO AUTOMATE

- Automated transaction matching between bank feed and ledger
- Exception flagging for unmatched items above a threshold
- Aged unreconciled items report generated automatically
- Match confidence scoring — high-confidence matches auto-cleared, low-confidence escalated
- ERP posting of matched items without manual journal entry

TOOL OPTIONS

BlackLine / ReconArt	Specialist reconciliation platforms with high-volume matching, exception management, and audit trail
SAP S/4HANA / Dynamics 365 / NetSuite	ERP-native reconciliation modules — suitable where transaction volumes are manageable and the ERP is already implemented
Xero / QuickBooks (SME)	Bank feed auto-matching built into the platform — effective for lower-volume entities

BEFORE YOU START — CHECKLIST

- ■ Cleanse your chart of accounts before implementing — dirty data produces poor match rates
- ■ Define your matching rules explicitly (exact match, fuzzy match within £X, date tolerance)
- ■ Set the threshold for auto-clearing vs human review — start conservative, loosen over time
- ■ Measure match rate weekly for the first 3 months — target 95%+ auto-matched
- ■ Never auto-clear items above a materiality threshold without human sign-off

04 Accounts Payable Invoice Processing

AP — invoice capture, coding, approval, and ERP posting

EFFORT: MEDIUM	IMPACT: HIGH	TIME TO VALUE: 6–12 weeks

WHY AUTOMATE THIS

AP invoice processing is one of the most paper-intensive, manual processes in finance. The combination of AI-powered OCR, automated 3-way matching, and workflow automation can eliminate the majority of manual touchpoints — reducing processing cost per invoice by 60–80% and dramatically improving payment accuracy.

WHAT TO AUTOMATE

- Invoice capture via OCR / AI — extracting supplier, amount, line items, VAT
- 3-way matching against PO and goods receipt
- Automated coding based on supplier history and category rules
- Approval routing for non-PO invoices and exceptions
- ERP posting and payment run preparation

TOOL OPTIONS

Basware / Coupa / Tradeshift	Enterprise AP automation platforms with full workflow, matching, and supplier portal
Microsoft AI Builder + Power Automate	For organisations in the Microsoft ecosystem wanting to build a lower-cost AP automation workflow
Rossum / ABBYY	AI-powered invoice capture layers that can sit in front of an existing ERP

BEFORE YOU START — CHECKLIST

- ■ Start with your top 20 suppliers by invoice volume — standardise their invoice format first
- ■ Define your 3-way match tolerance before configuration (e.g. within 2% or £50)
- ■ Map every exception type — the automation is only as good as its exception handling
- ■ Run parallel processing for the first month — manual and automated — before switching off the old process
- ■ Track cost per invoice before and after — this is your primary ROI metric

05 Management Reporting Pack Production

Reporting — automated data consolidation, chart refresh, and distribution

EFFORT: MEDIUM	IMPACT: HIGH	TIME TO VALUE: 4–10 weeks

WHY AUTOMATE THIS

The management reporting pack is produced every month, mostly by repeating the same manual steps: extract data from the ERP, paste into Excel, update charts, format the pack, email it out. This sequence is almost entirely automatable. The time saved is significant — typically 1–3 days per close cycle for a finance team of 5–10 people.

WHAT TO AUTOMATE

- Automated data extraction from ERP to reporting template
- Chart and table refresh without manual data pasting
- Variance calculation and conditional formatting applied automatically
- Pack assembly from component workbooks

- Scheduled distribution to defined recipients by role

TOOL OPTIONS

Power BI + Power Automate	Most effective combination for finance teams in the Microsoft ecosystem — live data connections, automated refresh, scheduled distribution
Workiva / Vena / Planful	Purpose-built financial reporting platforms with built-in workflow, versioning, and distribution
Excel + Python (pandas)	For teams with some technical capability — automated data pipeline feeding the existing Excel template

BEFORE YOU START — CHECKLIST

- ■ Standardise the pack format before automating — automation locks in whatever design you have
- ■ Connect to a single source of truth — eliminate the multiple-extract problem first
- ■ Build the automation around the existing template structure, not around what the tool prefers
- ■ Test with two consecutive closes before removing manual steps
- ■ Decide upfront whether to automate commentary or keep it human — commentary quality matters more than distribution speed

06 Budget vs Actual Variance Alerts

FP&A; — automated threshold monitoring with alert and commentary triggers

EFFORT: LOW | IMPACT: HIGH | TIME TO VALUE: 2–4 weeks

WHY AUTOMATE THIS

Most finance teams discover budget variances when they produce the monthly report. By then, the variance has been developing for weeks. Automated variance monitoring identifies significant deviations in near real-time — giving finance business partners time to investigate and respond before the month-end review.

WHAT TO AUTOMATE

- Automated comparison of actuals against budget as data posts to the ERP
- Alert generation when variance exceeds defined threshold (amount and %)
- Alert routing to the relevant finance business partner and budget holder
- Pre-populated variance commentary template triggered by the alert
- Weekly variance dashboard updated automatically

TOOL OPTIONS

Power BI with alert rules	Set data-driven alerts on KPIs — triggers email or Teams notification when threshold breached
Power Automate + Dataverse	For more complex routing logic — different thresholds by cost centre, different recipients by entity
Adaptive Insights / Anaplan	For organisations using dedicated planning tools — native variance monitoring with workflow

BEFORE YOU START — CHECKLIST

- ■ Define thresholds by cost centre type — a £5k variance is material in one context, immaterial in another
- ■ Send alerts to the finance business partner first, not directly to the budget holder
- ■ Include the variance amount, %, and the prior month trend in every alert — context matters
- ■ Set a maximum alert frequency — daily alerts on volatile lines produce alert fatigue
- ■ Review and recalibrate thresholds after 3 months based on alert volume and quality

07 Intercompany Reconciliation

Consolidation — automated matching and elimination of intercompany balances

EFFORT: MEDIUM | IMPACT: HIGH | TIME TO VALUE: 6–10 weeks

WHY AUTOMATE THIS

Intercompany reconciliation is the close task most likely to hold up the group consolidation. It is also one of the most automatable — the logic is rule-based, the data is structured, and the matching criteria are defined. Teams that automate intercompany reconciliation consistently reduce close duration by 1–2 days.

WHAT TO AUTOMATE

- Automated matching of intercompany AR and AP balances across entities
- Discrepancy identification and notification to both entity finance teams
- Resolution workflow for disputed balances
- Automated elimination journal preparation for the consolidation
- Month-end intercompany confirmation process between entities

TOOL OPTIONS

BlackLine Intercompany Hub	Purpose-built intercompany automation with matching, dispute management, and netting
SAP S/4HANA Intercompany	For SAP-centric groups — native intercompany reconciliation and elimination
Tagetik / OneStream	For groups using a dedicated consolidation platform — native intercompany automation built in

BEFORE YOU START — CHECKLIST

- ■ Establish a group intercompany policy before automating — mismatches are often caused by policy gaps, not system gaps
- ■ Define the master data for intercompany relationships in a single place before configuration
- ■ Agree the cut-off policy for intercompany transactions explicitly — in-transit items are the most common source of discrepancy
- ■ Run the reconciliation earlier in the close cycle — not at day-end on close day
- ■ Track discrepancy resolution time as a KPI — target under 24 hours for all entities

08 Cash Flow Forecasting Data Consolidation

Treasury — automated collection, consolidation, and refresh of cash forecast inputs

EFFORT: MEDIUM | IMPACT: HIGH | TIME TO VALUE: 4–8 weeks

WHY AUTOMATE THIS

Rolling cash flow forecasts typically require manual input collection from multiple business units or entities, followed by manual consolidation into a single model. Both steps are automatable. Automated collection removes the dependency on email submissions and ensures the forecast reflects the most current data available.

WHAT TO AUTOMATE

- Automated data pull from ERP for actual cash movements

- Structured input collection from business units via form or shared template
- Automated consolidation of entity-level forecasts into the group model
- Variance analysis between this week's forecast and last week's — automated
- Scheduled distribution of the consolidated forecast to treasury and CFO

TOOL OPTIONS

Excel + Power Query + Power Automate	Effective for teams with an existing Excel-based forecast model — automate the data collection and consolidation steps without rebuilding the model
Kyriba / GTreasury	Treasury management systems with native cash forecasting, bank connectivity, and automated consolidation
Anaplan / Adaptive Insights	Connected planning platforms — real-time consolidation from live entity inputs

BEFORE YOU START — CHECKLIST

■ Automate the data collection before automating the model — garbage in, garbage out

■ Standardise the input format across all entities before building the consolidation

■ Set a submission deadline and automate a reminder 24 hours before it — most forecast delays are caused by late inputs

■ Build a week-on-week variance report into the automated output — it is more useful than the forecast itself

■ Keep the model logic in Excel or the planning tool — do not try to move forecast logic into Power Automate

09 VAT Return Data Preparation

Tax — automated extraction, categorisation, and reconciliation of VAT data

EFFORT: MEDIUM | IMPACT: MEDIUM | TIME TO VALUE: 4–8 weeks

WHY AUTOMATE THIS

VAT return preparation requires extracting transactions from the ERP, categorising them by VAT treatment, reconciling to the ledger, and populating the return. Most of this is rule-based data processing that can be automated. Reducing manual preparation time also reduces the risk of coding errors that create VAT exposure.

WHAT TO AUTOMATE

- Automated extraction of VAT-relevant transactions from the ERP
- Rule-based categorisation by VAT treatment and rate
- Reconciliation of VAT ledger to transaction-level data
- Population of return template with extracted figures
- Exception report for transactions with missing or ambiguous VAT coding

TOOL OPTIONS

ERP native VAT reporting (SAP / Dynamics / NetSuite)	Most ERPs have built-in VAT reporting — the automation task is often configuring these correctly rather than building new tools
Vertex / Avalara	Tax automation platforms that integrate with ERPs to handle complex VAT determination across jurisdictions
Power Query / Python	For finance teams extracting VAT data from the ERP and processing it in Excel — automating the extraction and transformation steps

BEFORE YOU START — CHECKLIST

■ Ensure your chart of accounts has correct VAT tax codes on every account before building the automation

- ■ Build in a reconciliation check between the automated output and the VAT ledger — this is your primary control
- ■ Review the exception report every period — recurring exceptions indicate a master data or coding problem
- ■ Do not automate submission until you have run the automated preparation in parallel for at least 3 periods
- ■ Involve your tax adviser in reviewing the categorisation rules — VAT treatment is jurisdiction-specific and changes

10 Accounts Receivable Cash Allocation

AR — automated matching of customer payments to outstanding invoices

EFFORT: MEDIUM | **IMPACT: HIGH** | **TIME TO VALUE: 6–10 weeks**

WHY AUTOMATE THIS

Cash allocation in accounts receivable — matching incoming payments to open invoices — is one of the most time-intensive manual tasks in transactional finance. When customers pay partial amounts, pay multiple invoices in a single payment, or reference invoice numbers inconsistently, manual matching becomes a significant daily burden. AI-powered cash allocation can match 80–90% of transactions automatically.

WHAT TO AUTOMATE

- Automated matching of bank receipts to open AR invoices
- AI-powered fuzzy matching for partial payments and reference mismatches
- Remittance advice processing — extracting allocation information from PDF or email
- Exception workflow for unmatched receipts above a materiality threshold
- Automated dunning trigger when invoices remain unpaid past due date

TOOL OPTIONS

HighRadius / Billtrust / YayPay	AR automation platforms with AI-powered cash application, remittance processing, and collections workflow
SAP S/4HANA AR / Dynamics 365 Finance	ERP-native cash application with rule-based matching — effective where payment behaviour is consistent
Power Automate + AI Builder	For teams wanting to build a lightweight matching workflow within the Microsoft ecosystem

BEFORE YOU START — CHECKLIST

- ■ Analyse your current unmatched rate before starting — this is your baseline for measuring success
- ■ Classify your payment types (bank transfer, direct debit, card, cheque) — matching logic differs by type
- ■ Build the exception workflow first — every automation needs a reliable manual fallback for unmatched items
- ■ Set up remittance advice capture early — it significantly improves match rates for complex payers
- ■ Target 85%+ auto-match rate at 90 days — below 75% indicates a data quality or rules problem

RECOMMENDED IMPLEMENTATION SEQUENCE

PHASE 1 — QUICK WINS (MONTHS 1–3)

Task 1	**Expense Report Processing**	Immediate, visible time savings. Strong employee experience improvement. Builds appetite for further automation.
Task 2	**Month-End Close Management**	Low technical complexity. High visibility. Creates the close discipline that supports every subsequent automation.
Task 6	**Variance Alerts**	Builds on existing ERP data. Requires minimal configuration. Produces value immediately.

PHASE 2 — CORE CONTROLS (MONTHS 3–6)

Task 3	**Bank Reconciliation**	Requires clean chart of accounts — start after Phase 1 has forced data discipline.
Task 7	**Intercompany Reconciliation**	Build after bank rec is stable — similar logic, higher complexity.
Task 10	**AR Cash Allocation**	High-volume, clear ROI. Benefits from improved data quality established in Phase 1.

PHASE 3 — PROCESS AUTOMATION (MONTHS 6–12)

Task 4	**AP Invoice Processing**	Higher complexity — requires supplier engagement and ERP configuration. Do not attempt in Month 1.
Task 5	**Management Reporting**	Automate after the data sources are clean. Automating bad data production is not an improvement.
Task 8	**Cash Flow Forecasting**	Depends on clean actual data from Phase 2. Build the consolidation first, model second.
Task 9	**VAT Return Preparation**	Requires tax adviser input. Run in parallel for 3 periods before switching off manual process.

NEED SUPPORT WITH FINANCE AUTOMATION?

Mirela Dragulescu Consulting supports finance teams with AI readiness assessments, automation programme design, T&E platform implementation, and change management across European markets. Tailored proposals available on request.

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